

LOST IN TRANSITION? Tough, cumbersome process, centralised nods reduce job creation

2 months on, hit by teething trouble, VB-G RAM G lacks bite

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HUBBALLI, DHNS

The first two months of the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) have faced a series of administrative, technical and financial challenges in Karnataka, with officials at grassroots level struggling to adopt to a system that replaced the 2 decades-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA).

The new scheme came into force on July 1. Karnataka, which initially opposed the scheme, started implementing it on July 23.

Apart from delayed implementation, structural bottlenecks like new funding pattern, action plan approval through a centralised system and stringent procedures for execution of works have disrupted rural work generation.

“Unlike MGNREGA, which was a demand-driven system, VB-G RAM G requires prior approval from union government. In spite of being an online system, getting action plan approval takes at least 3-4 days,” said a panchayat development officer (PDO) in Koppal. He said this was affecting workers’ morale and triggering migration.

Waiting for jobs

Data from VB-G RAM G website shows that despite the drought-like situation, 805 of the 5,958 gram panchayats (GPs) have reported no expenditure. As a result, despite a large number of rural people across districts demanding work to navigate a failed monsoon, only 1.69 lakh households received work under the scheme in July and 3.51 lakh in August.

Raichur-based Gururaj Patil, state secretary of Grameena Koolikaarmikara Sanghatane, says compared to MGNREGS, there are a few added benefits in the new scheme, including 125 days of wage employment for every eligible rural household (100 days under MGNREGS) and possibility of selecting works from a list of 318 types (264 under MGNREGS). However, at GP level, PDOs are facing challenges, mostly when allocating work.

Co-ordination woes

“The new procedures require greater coordination between departments, online processing and adherence to revised technical requirements. Most PDOs are not able to execute them, resulting in workers not getting jobs on time. The new system has created additional responsibilities at panchayat level, particularly in planning, documentation and coordinating works. Grassroots-level officials have not received sufficient training,” said Patil. A PDO in Dharwad told *DH* that the technology-driven implementation of VB-G RAM G had become a hurdle for officials.

Tech glitches

“The system of creating nominal muster rolls (NMR) is not as easy as it was under MGNREGA. We are facing technical glitches,” said the PDO and added that lack of coordination between departments was resulting in lesser work being provided.

Earlier, agriculture, horticulture, forest, water supply, animal husbandry and other departments used to generate work and make payment to beneficiaries directly. However, now, while these departments generate work, the zilla



A file photo of workers toiling in the sun under the MGNREGA, which was replaced by the new job guarantee scheme, VB-G RAM G. Mandatory action plan approvals from the union government in the new scheme have retarded rural work generation. Officials in state say things will improve soon as they are plugging loopholes.

panchayat (ZP) has to monitor completion of work and make payment. Belagavi-based activist Vishveshwarayya Hiremath said there were also concerns over wage-payment process.

Pending dues

“Though the revised wage rates came into effect on July 1, and Karnataka’s notified rate is above Rs 360 a day, a majority of labourers have not received their pending wages for the last 3 months. This is deterring workers from joining the new scheme,” he said.

Hiremath says the biggest disadvantage of VB-G RAM G is that it lays more thrust on asset creation rather than employment generation or people-centric projects.

“Provisions have been made to repair school buildings, works related to anganwadis, check dams, drains and others. Under one GP, there will be a limited number of such construction works. The new scheme has

removed tasks like desilting of lakes and construction of bunds around fields, which are recurring and labour oriented”.

Sharada Gopal, founder of Jagruti Dharwad, says, “Nearly 75% of the work under VB-G RAM G is related to cement”.

Officials in rural development and panchayat raj (RDPR) department say these are initial days for VB-G RAM G and that Karnataka, like other states, was facing teething problems.

Addressing lapses

“When MGNREGA was introduced, we faced similar problems. As there was a lack of clarity from the state government over allocation of funds and acceptance of terms set by the union government, the department could not prepare action plans. However, compared to July, August has witnessed higher enrolment and work allocation. In the coming days, the scheme will be streamlined and all technical glitches

and procedural lapses will be addressed,” said a senior officer.

However, both grassroots-level officials and activists say the new scheme has not brought about any substantial changes that can prevent corruption, misuse of funds or improve monitoring of work implementation.

State to release funds

RDPR Minister Eshwar Khadre concedes that initially there was confusion over implementation of the scheme due to the union government’s tough stand on allocation of funds by state governments.

“Now, things are improving. We are creating awareness among PDOs and organising job card melas to improve enrolment. The government has decided to allocate sufficient funds for the scheme. In the coming days, we will achieve the target of creating 1.5 crore person-days a month,” he said.

No word on Kannadiga group in Nepal; kin cling to hope

ASRA MAVAD
BENGALURU, DHNS

Four middle-aged friends from Whitefield set out on a pilgrimage to Nepal, expecting a journey of faith and companionship. But since August 26, their families have had no word from them and have been unable to trace their whereabouts. As days pass without any clear information, anxious relatives cling to prayers and hope for a miracle that will bring the four back home safely.

Husband and wife Anagha, 49, and Venkataram Annamdevara, 52, were last known to be at the Nepal-Tibet border immigration centre around the time flash floods were recorded, their daughter Tanvi told *DH*.

“They were part of the Richa Tours/Hills and Trails group, and every person from the group, including the leader, has been unreachable since the morning of the floods. My parents are both engineers and had gone on the pilgrimage with two of their friends. They were excited for the trip,” Tanvi said.

“We’ve spoken to the Indian embassy, but they too have no information about the whereabouts of my parents or anyone from the group,” she added.

The group comprised 67 members, about 10 of them from Bengaluru.

Another set of four friends from Whitefield were also part of the group. Loganathan anxiously awaits any word on his friends — Shankar Venkatchallam, Srividya Shankar, Nellaipalli Ramakrishnan Kothandaraman and Rema Kothandaraman. “Some of us were colleagues, and we’ve known each other for 20 years. They are senior citizens, and it was their first time undertaking such a journey,” he said.

According to information gathered from family and friends, the group had just reached the immigration camp when flash floods struck the area around 8.30 am on August 26.

A group of 10 US and Canadian citizens, originally from Bengaluru and Udupi, also remain missing. “These are all Kannadigas — some family, some friends. They were travelling with Classic Vacations Nepal, and their last known location was Rasuwagadhi,” he said.

The group included Srinivas Sudhir, Sudhindra Yapalparvi, Laxminath Gopisetty, Venkataraman Balasubramanyam, Kirti Achary, Anil Goel, Venkat Keshav Rao, Mahendra Gupta, and Vivek Srivastav.

Tally of missing still uncertain

According to a Karnataka government statement, as of August 29, the State Emergency Operations Centre (SEOC) has collected details of 28 people from the state reported stranded or missing in Nepal and the Tibet Autonomous Region (TAR). Of these, 23 are from Bengaluru Urban district, two from Mysuru, one from Dharwad, one from Udupi and one from Vijayanagara.

Most are said to be in Timure, Rasuwa district of Nepal, while a few are in Darchen, Tibet Autonomous Region. Of the 28,

four have been confirmed safe and are transiting to Nepal. Search and tracing efforts are underway to locate the remaining 24.

However, the figure of 28 is unlikely to be the final count of Karnataka residents stranded or missing in Nepal and Tibet. *DH* found that the list compiled by the State Emergency Operations Centre includes some repeated names. In addition, some people who sought government aid did not provide details of all the missing persons, registering only one name instead.

RSS defamation case: Priyank, Nalapad get bail

BENGALURU, DHNS

Home Minister Priyank Kharge and state youth Congress president Mohammed Nalapad Haris on Saturday appeared before the special court for cases against MP/MLAs in connection with a defamation proceeding for alleged defamatory remarks against the RSS.

The special court released them on bail on executing personal bond of Rs 1 lakh each with cash surety of Rs 10,000 each.

The special court has issued summonses to Priyank and Nalapad in a private complaint alleging that they had made defamatory remarks against the RSS. The private

complaint was filed by Tejas A, an RSS member and resident of Bengaluru, in November 2025. The private complaint had also named former minister Dinesh Gundu Rao. The court, however, dropped allegations against Dinesh Gundu Rao.

During the hearing, charges under BNS Section 356 (Criminal defamation) were read out to both the accused. Both denied allegations and prayed for trial. The court has posted the matter to September 19 to record the evidence of the complainant in the case.

The complaint was filed close on the heels of the state government’s circular directing private organisations to seek permission prior to

holding events at government premises such as schools and parks. The circular was allegedly aiming to curb activities of the RSS.

During the issuance of this circular, Priyank had written to the then Chief Minister Siddaramaiah in October 2025, requesting a ban on RSS activities on government premises, including schools and grounds. The complaint further stated that Priyank subsequently posted on social media allegedly derogatory against the RSS.

According to the complaint, Nalapad too had posted certain comments against RSS on his social media handle which according to the petitioner were derogatory.

RESPLENDENT RAYARU



A grand ‘teppotsava’ marked Day One of the annual three-day aradhana celebrations of Raghavandraswami at Mantralayam in Andhra Pradesh.

Hegde was a ‘rightist thinker with leftist empathy’, says V-P

He refused to compromise on moral principles, recalls Siddu

BENGALURU, DHNS

Former chief minister Ramakrishna Hegde was a “rightist thinker with leftist empathy”, who was always accessible and principled, Vice President C P Radhakrishnan said on Saturday.

“He was a statesman and a institution builder and he pioneered decentralisation and grassroots democracy by enacting Panchayat Raj Act in 1985. He understood power must be balanced by accountability and revived and strengthened the Lokayukta,” Radhakrishnan said, addressing the gathering at Hegde’s birth centenary celebrations at the Vidhana Soudha here.

“The ruling party and the Opposition are not enemies — they are political rivals (rajakiya pratidwandi). This dis-

tinction must be kept in mind by everyone, whether in power or in Opposition, former vice president Venkaiah Naidu said.

“People are unhappy over what’s transpiring in Parliament and Assemblies today, as they want them to function. We may compete, win, or lose, but we must respect institutions and must agree to disagree,” the former vice president felt.

“Spirit of democratic discipline is the core lesson from the life of Hegde, a leader devoted to democratic decentralization, who strengthened the three-tier panchayat raj system and demonstrated character, calibre, capacity and conduct in public life,” he said.

Recalling that Hegde had proposed Sushma Swaraj’s candidature from Bellary in the 1999 Lok Sabha elections against Sonia Gandhi, Naidu recounted how he had also helped N T Rama Rao, then chief minister of Andhra Pradesh, by hosting 164 of his party MLAs in Mysuru for a month, before the crucial floor test.

Union Minister Pralhad



Vice-President C P Radhakrishnan pays tribute to former chief minister Ramakrishna Hegde during the latter’s birth centenary celebrations at Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru on Saturday. PTI PHOTO

Joshi said Hegde was charismatic and he, as a student, loved to listen to Hegde’s speeches alongside leaders like Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Jagannathrao Joshi.

Women’s quota

“Politics was his passion. He had keen interest in art, literature, theatre and cinema and brought youth from marginalized sections into governance and helped them build lasting legacies. As Karnataka’s first

non-Congress chief minister (1983), he introduced 25% reservation for women and implemented three-tier election system to decentralize power,” recalled Joshi.

The union minister urged Chief Minister D K Shivakumar to design programmes to introduce Hegde’s life and ideals to the new generation.

Former chief minister Siddaramaiah, who was a minister in Hegde’s Cabinet, recalled that despite not having

Karwar med college to be named after Hegde: CM

Chief Minister D K Shivakumar announced that the government would name the Karwar medical college and a major road in Bengaluru’s Shivaram Karanth Layout after Hegde, to commemorate his legacy. At Hegde’s birth centenary celebrations, Shivakumar announced plans to institute the ‘Ramakrishna Hegde best panchayat award’, to be presented annually.

“He was a leader who built leaders. I feel fortunate that he too represented my constituency (Kanakapura). Hegde’s politics transcended caste and was rooted in values, social justice and development,” Shivakumar said, adding his experiments in panchayat raj became a model for the country and later inspired the 73rd and 74th constitutional amendments.

an absolute majority, Hegde became the chief minister with the support of the BJP, communist party and independent members and ran a coalition government for two and a half years, with political tact and wisdom.

“When his party faced a setback in the 1984 parliamentary elections, Hegde dissolved the Assembly, sought a fresh mandate and won. When adverse court observations emerged

regarding the bottling license issue, he resigned immediately. During the telephone tapping controversy, he again stepped down, refusing to compromise on moral principles,” recalled Siddaramaiah. The veteran leader identified young political talent and mentored several future leaders, including Basavaraj Rayareddi, B L Shankar and R V Deshpande, the former chief minister said.

Govt constitutes vision group for skill development

BENGALURU, PTI: The government has constituted “Vision Group for Skill Development”, a high-level advisory body to provide strategic direction to Karnataka’s skilling ecosystem, officials said on Saturday.

The Vision Group has been constituted in furtherance of the Karnataka State Skill Policy 2025-32, which articulates the state’s commitment to building a future-ready, industry-relevant workforce across all regions and sectors of Karnataka, they said.

According to an official statement, the government has appointed Subroto Bagchi, Co-founder, Mindtree as the chairperson of the Vision Group. Bagchi is one of India’s most respected names in technology entrepreneurship and

institution-building.

Officials said that the Vision Group will advise the government on emerging priorities and gaps in skilling ecosystem, recommend strategic interventions to strengthen skilling ecosystem in Karnataka and provide guidance on the implementation of the State Skill Policy 2025-32.

Sharan Prakash Patil, Minister for Skill Development, Entrepreneurship and Livelihood, said, that the constitution of the Vision Group marks a significant step in government’s commitment to bringing the best minds in industry, academia, and civil society to the table.

Bagchi said that the youth of Karnataka will write a whole new book on skill development.

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